



minister. The building was inaugurated by him at an inauspicious time of the day, *Rahu Kalam*, after arriving late from a function. Many Congressmen have blamed its subsequent political reverses on the jinxed date with the stars and delayed the full-fledged shift of the party headquarters into the new building. After the Congress leadership distanced itself from the Gandhis, the first family started operating from the plot on Raisina Road, before returning to Akbar Road after Sitaram Kesari was defanged. The Raisina Road plot was later occupied by the multi-crore Rajiv Gandhi Foundation.

The National Youth Congress office at 5, Raisina Road, which was allotted to AICC on July 5, 1976 "as a purely temporary measure", is another property occupied by the party. A few years back, the rent arrears of the office

## SQUATTING RIGHTS: Jawahar Bhawan which was meant to be the Congress headquarters now houses the Rajiv Gandhi Foundation



SIPRA DAS



RUBEN SINGH

## EVICITION NOTICE: Headquarters of BJP (left) and the Congress will have to be vacated after the SC order

were estimated to be over Rs 18 lakh. The Congress now plans to move its frontal organisations to the new headquarters with amenities like a media centre, a full-floor office for the Congress president and a conference hall to hold meetings of the Congress Working Committee.

By treating prime estate in the capital as their own and modifying the original structures, political parties have played havoc with the vision of Edwin Lutyen, the architect who planned New Delhi 100 years ago. "These bungalows are meant to be residences. Political party offices have no business being there and should move out fast," says A.G.K. Menon, founder-member of Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage. The parties have been given three years' time to vacate the bungalows, identified by the World Monuments

Fund in New York as one of the planet's 100 most endangered heritage sites.

Another party which won't be getting much land this time is CPI. It had taken the trouble to set up a full-fledged office on subsidised land in 1971. The headquarters, Ajay Bhawan, was designed by well-known architect R. Jhabwala and is seen by many as a combat-ready structure that meets the "necessities of future class war". "Some see the sprawling bunker inside the party office as a part of the security apparatus," says a CPI leader. Others dismiss the underground hall, now a grand library, as a "bourgeois-deviation" by a top leader who had wanted to house a central air-conditioning system but whose plans were eventually shot down by others as it was considered incompatible with the principles of a proletarian party.

Such working class sentiments are rare in the race for an address that suits the working style of our political class.

## PROPERTY HUNT

- Under the new policy, land will be allotted to parties according to their parliamentary strength
- A party must have at least seven MPs to become eligible
- The Congress gets four acres, BJP two and CPI(M) one
- Smaller parties feel they are being given a raw deal
- Most parties are eyeing plots on DDU Marg, a real-estate hot spot
- CPI(M) finds itself on a street named after its ideological foe